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INTERVIEW

THE LUMINARY FROM SAULHEIM

How Vincent Keymer rose from a small-town prodigy to **global chess contender.**

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Every sport loves its wunderkinds — those marked for greatness early on, a picture of promise.

Not too long ago, German Grandmaster Vincent Keymer was one such child prodigy. The man who recognised his potential? Chess legend Garry Kasparov.

“Vincent is incredibly talented and can definitely make his way to the top of the chess world,” proclaimed Kasparov in 2015, after a two-hour training and analysis session with a 10-year-old Keymer in Berlin.

The German media soon hailed Keymer as the finest chess talent to emerge from the country since Emanuel Lasker, who reigned as world champion for 27 years, from 1894 to 1921.

Over the next decade, Keymer steadily worked towards the lofty target set for him by those around him. The IM title came in 2017; the GM tag followed two years later.

Consistent performances in prestigious events have seen him establish himself among the global chess elite.

Early in 2025, Keymer provided a stunning exhibition of his capabilities when he won the Weissenhaus Freestyle Chess Grand Slam against a world-class field on home turf.

He beat Alireza Firouzja, Magnus Carlsen and Fabiano Caruana — in that order — in the final three knockout

games, to achieve what he believes is the biggest tournament victory of his young career.

The burden of expectation, which has crushed many a wunderkind, has seemingly not affected Keymer. The key, according to him, is naivety.

“I didn’t really think about it [being a child prodigy] at the time. I was really quite naive in that sense. I just enjoyed chess.

“I played tournaments and tried to make things right with school. That’s pretty much all I did, and it worked,” says Keymer, speaking from the sidelines of the Chennai Grand Masters 2025.

It also helped that Keymer came from an environment far removed from the mechanical rigidity of chess.

His father, Christof, is a concert pianist and lecturer in piano at the Hanover University of Music, while his mother, Heike, is a cellist.

In fact, Keymer is a pianist himself — or rather, used to be one. “I played piano as a child, but that’s something that was sacrificed for the sake of chess. I haven’t played it for